

When I was seven years old my family moved to a small "company town" near Ada, Oklahoma. It was home to the families of all the men who worked at the Byng plant of the O.G. & E; Oklahoma Gas and Electric Company. The community was called Byng. It was located about a mile off of the highway which ran between Ada and Konawa. Situated on a high hilly area, the road into Byng wound up the hill and passed in front of Clayton's Store which was the filling station, general store and U.S. Post Office.

Just past the store was a large, broad, cattle guard entrance which led through a barbed wire fence. A car driving across this cattle guard created a clanking sound which always served to announce the entrance of anyone into Byng. Anyone, that is, who was in a car. After crossing the cattle guard, you would pass the water tower which ~~water~~ stood off to one side of the road. It was a steel structure which supported a large tank at the top. As a young boy, I climbed that tower many times, accepting the dares of my friends. It seemed extremely high to me at the time. Years later when I was a grown man I saw that water tower again and it looked small and far from the formidable climb which I had held in my memories. It was a disappointment to realize that my ~~staring~~ climbs were not so daring after all.

The road passed the tower and lead on down between two rows of frame houses. There were about twenty houses in all. One was the only one which was two stories high. It was the house that the boss's family lived in. My dad was chief engineer at the power generation plant, which meant he was in charge of the plant. He was the boss.

This fact put me in a position in which I was forced to prove myself. One, because I was considered as a "city boy" and two, because I was the boss's son. The other boys who lived in Byng were of various ages, some older and some younger. A few, perhaps three ~~or~~ four were my own age and eventually we all became good friends, but not before I was put through the ropes of showing that I could match skills and physical endurance with the rest of them.

One of my earliest tests was the simple act of "going barefooted." Country kids, boys and girls, simply didn't wear shoes in the summer time. As soon as school let out for summer vacation, shoes and socks became a forgotten item. Feet that were toughened by years of barefooted travel could walk across rough gravel roads with the greatest of ease. Sand bars and cobbles bars would bend and crush under the tread of ^{those} heavily calloused feet.

My first attempts at walking on gravel roads were comical. I would pick my way gingerly down the ~~road~~ ^{road}, seeking the area where the car tires had packed the gravel and made it less punishing to the tender soles of my feet.

If I dared to venture off the road, seeking the comfort of the grass and weeds along the side, before long I would step onto a patch of grass burs. Trying to hop around on one foot, picking burs out of my toes and heels they would stick just as readily into my fingers.

I kept at it though and by the end of ^{that first} summer was able to walk on gravel without hopping up and down like I was on a bed of hot coals. I also learned where the grass bur patches grew and avoided those areas, wisely so, for my feet never became tough enough to ~~cheerlessly~~ walk on them as some of my friends did.

Another test was to walk across the cattle guard, in mid-summer. Those smooth, shiny pipes would absorb the heat from the sun until they were too hot to touch. You had to walk across the guard, stepping on every pipe, one at a time. With each succeeding step the heat penetrated farther into your feet. At the end of your walk across those pieces of pipe it was permitted to holler. Your yell could mean either triumph or pain. It usually stood for both.

Some times after our walk across the cattle guard, our hardy group would go on into Clayton's store for a bottle of soda pop. It was kept in a metal cooler, floating in water which was chilled by large chunks of ice. They had flavors like Nehi orange crush, strawberry, grape, lemon, cherry. They even had a chocolate flavor. Coca-cola was popular then also, but in those days it

was referred to by its full name. The term "Coke" had not come into general useage.

After cooling off ~~for~~ with our drinks we would sit out under the roofed drive area where the tall, hand ^{operated} ~~pump~~ gasoline pumps were located. We would sit, waiting patiently for someone to drive up to buy gasoline. When a customer would finally appear, Mr. Clayton would come outside, ask the person how much gas they wanted, then pick one of us to pump up the requested number of gallons into the glass cylinder at the top of the pump housing.

"One, two, three, four, five." We would count in unison as the gasoline rose past the markers on the side of the cylinder.

"Five, four, three, two, one." This would be our chant as the gas ran into the customer's tank.

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"Betcha won't climb the water tower"

That was one of the many challenges given to me that first summer. The tower was only about thirty or forty feet tall, but to a seven year old boy it seemed more like a hundred. Standing at its base, looking up the small ladder toward the top, clouds scudding past the tank created an illusion of movement that made you dizzy if you stared at the top too long.

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It really wasn't a difficult climb, certainly nothing that required much physical stamina. No, it was purely a test of nerve. You either had the nerve to climb the tower or you didn't. I'm glad to say that I had the nerve. ~~My name was~~ ^{I wrote my name} written in heavy pencil on the side of the steel tank alongside of Homer's, and Buddie, and Sap, and Leon, and Booter Ray, and even Virginia.

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It was called Big Sandy Creek. A name which seems to be used quite commonly for sandy bottomed water courses throughout our land. This particular Big Sandy was the "swimming hole" for our gang of kids. The banks were steeply sloping along most of its length but there was one particular area with a steep bank on one side and a flatter area on the opposite side. It was an ideal area for swimming and having a good time rolling in the sand. There was a large rope swing tied to a high limb on a big cottonwood tree. You could grab the rope and swing out into the middle of the creek and drop into the water. If you swung hard enough you could swing all the way across the creek and land in the sand on the other side. It was an ideal place for country boys to frolic and have a good time in the water.

There was only one problem.

I didn't know how to swim.

I couldn't swim but I wasn't going to admit it when we went to the creek for our first time that summer. Bathing suits weren't used in the country. You shucked your clothes and jumped in.

I went into the ^{dark, cool} water and managed to tread water and dog paddle ~~myself~~ about half-way across. My arms and legs began to grow tired. ~~as~~ I was tense - not relaxed as an experienced swimmer would be. My struggle against the water began to turn to panic as I realized I wouldn't have the strength to get to the opposite bank. My impulse was to yell for help, but I held back. Ashamed to admit I needed help, I continued to tread water. Visions of my mother crying over my drowned body flashed through my mind. I don't want to drown, I knew that. Just as I was prepared to cry for help my foot touched bottom!

I was able to stand on the bottom with water just about chest high. Walking the rest of the way I pulled myself up onto the gently sloping bank and fell onto the sand. My body was exhausted. I waited until I had gotten my wind and strength back. My plan for returning to the other side was to walk into the water as far as I could. If I could only make it half way in that manner, the rest could be accomplished by dog paddling. Luckily my plan worked and I survived the ^{afternoon} crossing.

The others were waiting for me when I climbed up the bank. As we were putting our clothes back on, Homer said to me, "Hey, why didn't you say you can't swim?"

"We'll teach you, don't worry about it."

And they did.

By the end of summer I could ~~swim~~^{swim} back and forth
across Big Sandy several times without stopping.
My ~~new friends~~^{new friends} always kidded me, ~~however~~^{however} about my first
swim in the creek.

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